

The art of farts

关于“肠道排气”的科学

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它常常让人感到尴尬、难以启齿，甚至在公共场合极力避免发生，但本文将试着从一个全新的角度探讨“fart（屁）”这一自然的生理现象。其实，对大多数哺乳动物来说，放屁是消化系统的正常运作的表现之一。而对部分动物来说，比如蛇类和昆虫，放屁甚至是求生、防御或沟通的手段。阅读短文，了解屁背后的科学解释。

词汇: biology 生物学

1 It's a topic people usually avoid, yet it's a universal human experience. Flatulence, affectionately known as farting, is simply the releasing of gas from the backside. The word itself traces back to the Latin 'flatus', which literally means 'a blowing' or 'wind.' While it is often the butt of the joke, we do it for very practical reasons, which boil down to digestion. Most mammals have a complex, symbiotic relationship with their gut microbes which break down food. Digestion requires a lengthy process of fermentation, and flatulence is simply the inevitable byproduct of these hard-working bacteria. Passing gas is a sign of a highly functioning digestive system.

2 But we humans aren't the only mammals that like to let one off. In 2017, National Geographic and the BBC reported the results of an online survey. It revealed some incredibly unlikely farters, like zebras, which have been documented farting with every single step whilst running away from predators. On a bigger scale, cow flatulence and burps are packed with methane, a potent greenhouse gas that is actively driving global climate change. And, if you've ever had a domesticated pet, you might've even blamed your own farts on them! I know I have.

3 There are other fascinating examples of farting from the animal kingdom. The Sonoran coral snake expels air forcefully to startle predators when it's in danger. In an article published on The Conversation, it's mentioned that herring, a type of fish, will release gas as a way to communicate with each other that predators are nearby. It was also written in IFLScience that the beaded lacewing, a type of larva, can take down six termites with one fart!

4 So it seems that some animals pass gas as an evolutionary survival tactic. Those not so 'silent but deadly' farts can ward off predators as well as let others know that there's potential danger. While farts for us are mainly the result of digestion, perhaps, like the Sonoran snake, herring and beaded lacewing, we could embrace the breeze and utilise them against our enemies? Hahaha, just joking!

测验与练习

一、为本文选择总结句。

a. Animals farting is a major problem. b. Farting is natural – a lot of animals fart. c. Most mammal fart when they're in danger.

二、根据文章内容选出正确的选项。

1. Passing gas is a sign that there is an issue or malfunction in a person's digestive system. a. True b. False c. Not given

2. According to the text, why do Sonoran coral snakes expel air forcefully? a. They do it as a response to running away from predators. b. They do it to communicate with others that there are predators nearby. c. They do it to startle chasing predators.

3. Methane is a type of gas that... a. accelerates climate change. b. helps slow down climate change. c. makes a cow's gut healthier.

4. The gas released by herring contains toxic chemicals. a. True b. False c. Not given

5. The beaded lacewing larva can kill up to six termites at a time with a single fart. a. True b. False c. Not given

三、用下列单词完成对本文的总结。

For most animals, farts are a natural 1) _____ of 2) _____ in the digestive system. But for some animals, they are used as a 3) _____ when they feel they're in danger. They 4) _____ either to communicate with others about predators, or to 5) _____ predators, giving them a chance to escape!

startle let one off greenhouse gas blame byproduct fermentation tactic

(答案见词汇表后)

词汇表

the butt of the joke

被取笑的对象 boil down to 归结为 symbiotic 共生的 microbe 微生物 fermentation 发酵 inevitable 无法避免的 byproduct 副产物 let one off (无意中)放屁(委婉说法) potent 强效的, 效果明显的 greenhouse gas 温室气体 domesticated 家养的 blame 责怪, 责备 animal kingdom 动物界 expel 排出 startle 使...受惊吓 take down 消灭, 击倒 tactic 策略, 手段 silent but deadly 无声但杀伤力十足 ward off 抵挡, 驱离 embrace 欣然接受 utilise 有效利用

答案

一、为本文选择总结句。

b. Farting is natural – a lot of animals fart.

二、根据文章内容选出正确的选项。

1. b. False. Passing gas is a sign of a highly functioning digestive system .

2. c. The Sonoran coral snake expels air forcefully to startle predators when it's in danger .
3. a. On a bigger scale, cow flatulence and burps are packed with methane, a potent greenhouse gas that is actively driving global climate change .
4. c. Not given. While the text confirms that herring use flatulence to communicate about nearby predators, it does not mention what kind of chemicals that the gas contains.
5. a. True. ...beaded lacwing, a type of larva, can take down six termites with one fart !

三、用下列单词完成对本文的总结。

For most animals, farts are a natural byproduct of fermentation in the digestive system. But for some animals, they are used as a tactic when they feel they're in danger. They let one off either to communicate with others about predators, or to startle predators, giving them a chance to escape!

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